

doc-body-soul-constitution

Affirms · Anthropology › Constitution of Man · doctrine · divided_lineages · Brethren distinctive · confidence: high

Statement under examination

Human beings are a unity of material body and immaterial soul/spirit; whether constitution is dichotomous (body+soul) or trichotomous (body+soul+spirit) is a debated but in-house question.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical demonstration. Genesis 2:7 narrates a two-step constitution: God forms (yatsar H3335) the man from the dust (aphar H6083) of the ground and then breathes (naphach H5301) into his nostrils the breath of life (neshamah H5397), at which point the man becomes a living being (nephesh chayyah H5315 + H2416). Ecclesiastes 12:7 inversely separates the components at death: the dust (aphar H6083) returns (shuv H7725) to the earth as it was, and the spirit (ruach H7307) returns (shuv H7725) to God who gave it (nathan H5414). Matthew 10:28 fixes the dualism in the words of Jesus: do not fear those who kill (apokteinō G615) the body (sōma G4983) but cannot kill the soul (psychē G5590); fear the one who can destroy (apollumi G622) both soul and body in hell. The two are lexically distinguished and separately killable or destroyable. The intermediate-state passages confirm a conscious post-mortem immaterial component: Luke 23:43 (today you will be with me in paradise, paradeisos G3857), Phil 1:23 (the desire to depart, analuō G360, and be with Christ, syn Christō G4862 + G5547), 2 Cor 5:8 (away from the body, ekdēmeō G1553, at home with the Lord, endēmeō G1736), Heb 12:23 (the spirits, pneuma G4151, of the righteous made perfect), Rev 6:9 (the souls, psychē G5590, of those who had been slain, under the altar). Whether the immaterial component is one (soul=spirit, dichotomism) or two (soul and spirit distinct, trichotomism) is a sub-debate: 1 Thess 5:23 (your whole, holoklēros G3648, spirit, pneuma G4151, and soul, psychē G5590, and body, sōma G4983) and Heb 4:12 (dividing, merismos G3311, soul and spirit, psychē G5590 and pneuma G4151) are cited for trichotomy, while psychē and pneuma are interchangeably used elsewhere (Mary's soul magnifies, Luke 1:46-47 parallel; Jesus commits his spirit, Luke 23:46, John 19:30) supporting dichotomy. The CORE proposition that humans are a unity of material body and immaterial soul/spirit is canonically settled regardless of how the sub-debate resolves.

Reasoning

Verdict: a human being is made of two things: a physical body, and an immaterial part the Bible calls soul or spirit. Both belong together. The body is not a prison and the soul is not the whole person. The two come together to make one human being. The strongest reason from Scripture is the way the Bible describes creation and death. In Genesis 2:7, God forms the man from the dust of the ground, then breathes the breath of life into him, and the man becomes a living being. The body is made first, then the breath of God animates it. In Ecclesiastes 12:7, the same separation happens in reverse at death: the dust returns to the earth as it was, and the spirit returns to God who gave it. Two components, distinguished. In Matthew 10:28, Jesus says do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul; fear the one who can destroy both soul and body in hell. The body can be killed without the soul being killed, which means they are not the same thing. After death, the Bible describes people existing in a conscious immaterial state before the resurrection: Jesus tells the thief on the cross today you will be with me in paradise, on the day they both died. Paul writes in Philippians 1:23 that he desires to depart and be with Christ, which is far better. In 2 Corinthians 5:8 he says he is willing to be away from the body and at home with the Lord. In Revelation 6:9 John sees the souls of those who had been killed for the word of God, under the altar, crying out. The strongest counterargument comes from passages that describe death as sleep and from

passages where the soul-words (Hebrew *nephesh*, Greek *psychē*) can mean simply life or the whole living person. Critics like Seventh-day Adventists, Jehovah's Witnesses, and Christadelphians teach soul-sleep, that the soul ceases conscious existence at death and is recreated at resurrection. They point to passages like Ecclesiastes 9:5 the dead know nothing, Psalm 6:5 in death there is no remembrance of you, and the frequent biblical description of death as sleep. The verdict handles this by noting that the sleep-language is a metaphor for the body's stillness as seen by the living, while the passages describing the dead as conscious and located with Christ or under the altar describe the immaterial state directly. Ecclesiastes 9:5 is wisdom literature describing what the dead no longer participate in from under the sun, not a denial of post-mortem consciousness. A separate sub-debate within historic Christianity is whether the immaterial component is one thing called soul-and-spirit interchangeably, or whether soul and spirit are two distinct parts.

Denominational landscape

The CORE proposition (humans are body and immaterial soul/spirit) is universally affirmed across historic Christianity. Patristic: Augustine and the Latin tradition lean dichotomist (body and soul, with soul including the rational spirit). Irenaeus (Against Heresies V.6) and Tertullian, and some Eastern fathers, lean trichotomist (body, soul, and spirit). Catholic: the Catechism, paragraphs 362 to 368, teaches the human person as a being at once corporeal and spiritual, with the soul created immediately by God and immortal, and the unity of soul and body such that the soul is the form of the body. Dichotomist in formal structure. Lutheran: the Book of Concord confesses the immortal soul and bodily resurrection without legislating between dichotomy and trichotomy. Anglican: the 39 Articles affirm bodily resurrection and the immortal soul, dichotomist in standard interpretation. Reformed: the Westminster Confession 32.1 teaches the bodies of men, after death, return to dust and see corruption, but their souls, which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them. Explicitly dichotomist and explicitly anti-soul-sleep. Methodist: Wesley preserves the Anglican formula; mainstream Methodism is dichotomist. Anabaptist: the Dordrecht Confession affirms the immortal soul and bodily resurrection. Pentecostal: the Assemblies of God and many Pentecostal traditions historically lean trichotomist (body, soul, and spirit, derived from 1 Thessalonians 5:23), though without making it a confessional boundary. Eastern Orthodox: dichotomy is the dominant Eastern position with significant trichotomist voices, and the immortal soul with conscious intermediate state is universally taught. Public-record carriers of denial of the CORE or of the intermediate state: Seventh-day Adventists teach conditional immortality and soul-sleep, that the soul is not naturally immortal and is unconscious between death and resurrection. They affirm the Trinity, deity of Christ, and bodily resurrection, so most ecumenical bodies treat Adventist soul-sleep as heterodox but not cult-grade. Jehovah's Witnesses teach the soul perishes at death and is recreated at resurrection, bundled with their denial of the Trinity and of Christ's full deity, which together place them outside historic Christianity. Christadelphians teach a similar soul-sleep position bundled with anti-Trinitarianism. Mormonism teaches a pre-existent spirit that joins a body at conception, then continues post-mortem before resurrection, a different deviation altogether (the immateriality of the spirit is denied; Mormon doctrine teaches that all spirit is matter, just more refined). New Age and pantheistic systems collapse body into illusion or treat all reality as a single immaterial substance, the opposite error of physicalism. Christian materialism (non-reductive physicalism, held by some contemporary evangelical philosophers including Nancey Murphy, Joel Green, and Kevin Corcoran) denies any separable immaterial soul and holds that the resurrection of the body is the basis of post-mortem existence, with no intermediate disembodied state. This position remains in-house and contested among confessing Trinitarian Christians; most historic traditions treat it as heterodox to the conscious-intermediate-state strand of historic teaching. The CORE (body plus immaterial) is would-die-for orthodoxy; the dichotomy-vs-trichotomy sub-debate and the intermediate-state details remain in-house.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

The proposition has two layers. Layer 1 (CORE): humans are constituted of a material body and an immaterial soul/spirit. This is universally affirmed across historic Christianity (patristic, Catholic, Lutheran, Anglican, Reformed, Methodist, Anabaptist, Pentecostal, Eastern Orthodox). Layer 2 (IN-HOUSE): whether the immaterial component is one (dichotomism: body+soul/spirit) or two (trichotomism: body+soul+spirit) is a long-standing internal debate. Western theology since Augustine and Aquinas has leaned dichotomist; Eastern fathers including Irenaeus (Against Heresies V.6) and Tertullian, and modern Pentecostal and Brethren traditions, have leaned trichotomist; the Westminster tradition is dichotomist; the Catholic Catechism is dichotomist (CCC 365 names soul as form of body). On the cult-marker bar: full physicalist denial of any immaterial component (Christian materialism / non-reductive physicalism, e.g., Nancey Murphy, Joel Green, Kevin Corcoran in contemporary evangelical philosophy) IS heterodox to historic Christianity, but is in-house philosophical-theological disagreement among confessing Christians, not cult-grade denial. Soul-sleep advocates (Seventh-day Adventists, Jehovah's Witnesses, Christadelphians) teach the soul ceases conscious existence at death and is recreated at resurrection. Adventist soul-sleep is treated as heterodox-not-cult in most ecumenical frames (Adventism affirms the Trinity, deity of Christ, bodily resurrection); JW and Christadelphian soul-sleep is bundled with their broader anti-Trinitarian cult-marker, but the soul-sleep position itself in isolation is not cult-grade. The CORE proposition (body+immaterial) is would-die-for; the in-house sub-debate (one immaterial component or two) is not. Public-record carriers of denial of the CORE: full physicalism (small minority of evangelical philosophers; in-house contested), New Age monism (immaterial only, illusory body), gnostic spiritualism (body evil, soul good, opposite error). Public-record soul-sleep carriers: Seventh-day Adventists (Ellen White, Adventism teaches conditional immortality and soul-sleep), Jehovah's Witnesses (Watchtower teaches the soul perishes at death), Christadelphians (John Thomas, similar position). Honest cult_marker_if_denied=false: full physicalism remains a position held by some confessing Trinitarian Christians with credentialed philosophical-theological arguments, and soul-sleep does not deny a core Trinitarian or Christological boundary.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. classical_dichotomism, trichotomism, christian_materialism, soul_sleep_mortalism, thomistic_hylomorphism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Competing lens verdicts

- affirms:
- affirms:
- denies:
- denies_intermediate_state:
- affirms:

Grammatico-historical exegesis of Gen 2:7 plus Eccl 12:7 establishes the two-step constitution and reverse decomposition: the human is dust plus divine breath, and at death the dust returns to earth while the ruach returns to God. Matthew 10:28 confirms the body/soul lexical distinction in dominical teaching. The intermediate-state texts (Luke 23:43, Phil 1:23, 2 Cor 5:8, Heb 12:23, Rev 6:9, Luke 16:22) provide the strongest positive witness for conscious post-mortem existence of the immaterial component before bodily resurrection. The wisdom-literature texts (Eccl 9:5, Ps 146:4) cited by soul-sleep advocates are phenomenological-language descriptions of bodily-life cessation from the perspective of the living, not denials of post-mortem conscious existence. Analogia scripturae integrates apocalyptic, narrative, and epistolary witness against the wisdom-literature texts read in isolation. Progressive revelation: the OT establishes the two-component anthropology (Gen 2:7, Eccl 12:7, Job 14:22), the NT develops it explicitly with the intermediate-state passages, culminating in Christ's own pneuma-into-Father's-hands at his death (Luke 23:46) and Stephen's pneuma-receive-Lord-Jesus at his death (Acts 7:59). The dichotomy-vs-trichotomy sub-debate operates inside this affirmed CORE: 1 Thess 5:23 and Heb 4:12 underdetermine between the two readings, and historic Christianity has hosted both. Christian materialism remains the in-house challenge; soul-sleep mortalism remains the heterodox-but-not-cult challenge bundled with non-Trinitarian groups for JW and Christadelphians and held alone by Adventism

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Gen.2.7 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. הָיָה שָׁפָן לְקִדָּה יְהִי מִיָּח תִּמְשֵׁן וַיִּפָּאֵב תַּפְּיוּ הַמִּדְבָּה־נָּם רָפָע קִדְבָה־תָּא מִיְהִלָּא הוּהִי רָצִיוּ. yatsar H3335 Qal consecutive imperfect 3ms; aphar H6083 noun masculine singular; naphach H5301 Qal consecutive imperfect 3ms; neshamah H5397 noun feminine singular construct; chayyim H2416 noun masculine plural; hayah H1961 Qal consecutive imperfect 3ms; nephesh H5315 noun feminine singular

Force. 'Then the LORD God formed (yatsar) the man of dust (aphar) from the ground and breathed (naphach) into his nostrils the breath (neshamah) of life (chayyim), and the man became (hayah) a living being (nephesh chayyah).' Two-step constitution: material (aphar) plus divine inbreathing (neshamah). The man becomes (hayah) a nephesh, he does not receive a nephesh as a separate part. The verse establishes that the human person is constituted of dust-stuff plus divine breath, the foundational anthropology of the canon

Eccl.12.7 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: parallelism

Key term. אָפּהאַר אַ שׁוּב אַרֶּצְתָּ אֶת־רוּחְךָ אֶל־אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֶת־אָפּהַר אֶל־אֶרֶץ אֶת־רוּחְךָ אֶל־אֱלֹהֶיךָ; aphar H6083; shuv H7725 Qal imperfect 3ms (twice); eretz H776; ruach H7307 noun feminine singular; nathan H5414 Qal perfect 3ms

Force. 'The dust (aphar) returns (shuv) to the earth (eretz) as it was, and the spirit (ruach) returns (shuv) to God who gave it (nathan).' Inverse of Gen 2:7: at death the two components separate. Dust to earth, ruach to God. The two parallel return-clauses with the same verb shuv establish that two distinguishable components are in view, and the immaterial ruach has an origin in God and a return to God, while the dust has an origin in earth and a return to earth

Matt.10.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. μὴ φοβεῖσθε ἀπὸ τῶν ἀποκτείνοντων τὸ σῶμα τὴν δὲ ψυχὴν μὴ δυναμένων ἀποκτείνειν φοβεῖσθε δὲ μᾶλλον τὸν δυνάμενον καὶ ψυχὴν καὶ σῶμα ἀπολέσαι ἐν γεέννῃ; apokteinō G615 present active participle masculine genitive plural; sōma G4983 accusative singular; psychē G5590 accusative singular; apollumi G622 aorist active infinitive; gehenna G1067; phobeō G5399 present middle imperative 2p

Force. 'Do not fear those who kill (apokteinō) the body (sōma) but cannot kill (apokteinō) the soul (psychē). Rather fear him who can destroy (apollumi) both soul and body in hell (gehenna).' Jesus lexically distinguishes sōma and psychē. The two are separately killable. Body can be killed without soul being killed, which entails the soul has an existence not coextensive with bodily life. The phrase 'destroy both soul and body in hell' applies to final eschatological judgment after resurrection, not to natural death

Luke.23.43 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀμήν σοι λέγω σήμερον μετ' ἐμοῦ ἔσῃ ἐν τῷ παραδείσῳ; sēmeron G4594; meta G3326; paradeisos G3857

Force. 'Truly I say to you, today (sēmeron) you will be with (meta) me in paradise (paradeisos).' Jesus speaks to the dying thief about a today-with-me state that begins on the day of bodily death, before the future bodily resurrection. The immaterial component of both Jesus and the thief is what arrives in paradeisos that day. Direct testimony to conscious post-mortem existence before bodily resurrection

Phil.1.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τὴν ἐπιθυμίαν ἔχων εἰς τὸ ἀναλῦσαι καὶ σὺν Χριστῷ εἶναι πολλῶν γὰρ μᾶλλον κρεῖσσον; analuō G360 aorist active infinitive; syn G4862; Christos G5547 dative singular; kreissōn G2908 comparative

Force. 'My desire is to depart (analuō) and be with (syn) Christ, for that is far better (kreissōn).' Paul anticipates an immediate post-mortem with-Christ state that is better than embodied apostolic ministry. The departing is not annihilation followed by future recreation; it is a transition into a conscious with-Christ condition. Soul-sleep cannot integrate this lexical force

2Cor.5.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. θαρροῦμεν δὲ καὶ εὐδοκοῦμεν μᾶλλον ἐκδημῆσαι ἐκ τοῦ σώματος καὶ ἐνδημῆσαι πρὸς τὸν Κύριον; ekdēmeō G1553 aorist active infinitive; sōma G4983; endēmeō G1736 aorist active infinitive; kyrios G2962

Force. 'We are of good courage, and we would rather be away (ekdēmeō) from the body (sōma) and at home (endēmeō) with the Lord (kyrios).' The two verbs (ekdēmeō, away-from-residence; endēmeō, at-home-in-residence) are spatial-relational, predicating a personal subject who relocates from body to Lord. The subject persists through the transition. Direct intermediate-state testimony

Heb.12.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πνεύμασι δικαίων τετελειωμένων; pneuma G4151 dative neuter plural; dikaios G1342 genitive masculine plural; teleioō G5048 perfect passive participle

Force. 'You have come to the spirits (pneuma) of the righteous made perfect (teleioō perfect passive).' The heavenly assembly includes pneumata of righteous human persons in the perfected state. The perfect passive teleioō describes a completed state in which these spirits now exist, before bodily resurrection. The lexical witness for the conscious intermediate state of the immaterial component is direct

Rev.6.9 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: apocalyptic-symbolism

Key term. εἶδον ὑποκάτω τοῦ θυσιαστηρίου τὰς ψυχὰς τῶν ἐσφαγμένων διὰ τὸν λόγον τοῦ Θεοῦ; psychē G5590 accusative plural; sphazō G4969 perfect passive participle; thysiaστήριον G2379

Force. 'I saw under the altar (thysiaστήριον) the souls (psychē) of those who had been slain (sphazō perfect passive) for the word of God.' The martyrs have been slain (their bodies killed) yet their psychai are present, conscious, and crying out (v.10). The text predicates location (under the altar), perception, speech, and waiting on the psychē after bodily death and before bodily resurrection (v.11 they receive white robes and are told to wait)

1Thess.5.23 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key term. ὁλόκληρον ὑμῶν τὸ πνεῦμα καὶ ἡ ψυχὴ καὶ τὸ σῶμα ἀμέμπτως ἐν τῇ παρουσίᾳ τοῦ Κυρίου ἡμῶν Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τηρηθεῖν; holoklēros G3648 nominative; pneuma G4151 nominative singular; psychē G5590 nominative singular; sōma G4983 nominative singular; hagiazō G37

Force. 'May your whole (holoklēros) spirit (pneuma) and soul (psychē) and body (sōma) be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.' The three terms appear in coordinate construction. The trichotomist reading takes pneuma and psychē as distinct components; the dichotomist reading takes them as two aspects of one immaterial component, with the threefold list naming aspects of the whole person for emphasis. Either way, the verse undergirds the CORE: more than body is in view, an immaterial component (whether one or two) is part of human constitution

Heb.4.12 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. διϊκνούμενος ἄχρι μερισμοῦ ψυχῆς καὶ πνεύματος ἁρμῶν τε καὶ μυελῶν; diikneomai G1338 present middle participle; merismos G3311 genitive singular; psychē G5590 genitive singular; pneuma G4151 genitive singular; harmos G719 genitive plural; myelos G3452 genitive plural

Force. 'The word of God is living, piercing (diikneomai) to the division (merismos) of soul (psychē) and spirit (pneuma), of joints (harmos) and marrow (myelos).' The verse predicates a divisible relation between psychē and pneuma. Trichotomists read this as proof that soul and spirit are distinct components; dichotomists read merismos as the word's penetration into the deepest seat of inner life, with psychē and pneuma as the two ways the inner life is described (parallel to joints/marrow as bodily depth). Either way the verse supports an immaterial inner-life as a real component

Gen.35.18 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. וַיִּבְרַח נֶפֶשׁ יָצָאָהּ; nephesh H5315 noun feminine singular; yatsa H3318 Qal infinitive construct

Force. 'As her soul (nephesh) was departing (yatsa), for she was dying, she called his name Ben-oni.' Rachel's nephesh departs at death. The departing-soul language treats the nephesh as a component that exits the body when life ends. Direct lexical witness to the separability of the immaterial component from the body at death

1Kgs.17.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. וּבָרַק־לֵע הָזֶה דְּלִיָּהּ־שָׁפָנוּ אֶנְיָ־בָשֶׁת; nephesh H5315; shuv H7725 Qal imperfect 3fs jussive

Force. 'O LORD my God, let this child's soul (nephesh) return (shuv) into him again.' Elijah prays for the dead child's nephesh to return into him. The departed nephesh is treated as a real entity that can return when God restores life. Lexical confirmation of the body/nephesh separability and reunion at resuscitation

Luke.23.46 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. Πάτερ εἰς χεῖράς σου παρατίθεμαι τὸ πνεῦμά μου; pneuma G4151 accusative singular; paratithēmi G3908 present middle indicative 1s

Force. 'Father, into your hands I commit (paratithēmi) my spirit (pneuma).' At the moment of bodily death Jesus commends his pneuma to the Father. Direct first-person predication: the bodily death is a separation of pneuma from sōma, with the pneuma transferred to the Father's keeping. Foundational dominical witness to the immaterial component's departure at death

Acts.7.59 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. Κύριε Ἰησοῦ δέξαι τὸ πνεῦμά μου; pneuma G4151 accusative singular; dechomai G1209 aorist middle imperative 2s

Force. 'Lord Jesus, receive my spirit (pneuma).' Stephen at his stoning addresses Christ and asks him to receive his pneuma. Parallels Luke 23:46 dominically. The dying believer's pneuma is treated as a real entity that the risen Christ receives directly at the moment of bodily death

Jas.2.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ὥσπερ γὰρ τὸ σῶμα χωρὶς πνεύματος νεκρὸν ἐστίν; sōma G4983; chōris G5565; pneuma G4151; nekros G3498

Force. 'For as the body (sōma) without (chōris) the spirit (pneuma) is dead (nekros).' James predicates that the body's life is contingent on the presence of the pneuma; absence of pneuma equals nekros body. Direct definitional witness to the body-plus-immaterial constitution. The pneuma is what makes the sōma alive

Eccl.9.5 · complicates · genre: wisdom · figures: phenomenological-language

Key term. יֹדְעֵי חַיִּים יִתְּנוּ מִתְּמָהוּ וְתִמְנָשׁ מִיַּעְדֵּי מוֹתָהוּ; chay H2416 plural participle; yada H3045 Qal participle; muth H4191 Qal imperfect; meth H4191 Qal participle

Force. 'The living know that they will die, but the dead know nothing.' Cited by soul-sleep advocates as proof that the dead are unconscious. Complicates the verdict only at a surface reading. The wisdom-literature context speaks of what the dead no longer participate in under the sun (v.6 'they have no more share forever in anything done under the sun'). Qoheleth is describing the cessation of bodily-life activities from the perspective of the living, not the metaphysical state of the immaterial component. Read alongside the explicit intermediate-state texts (Luke 23:43, Phil 1:23, 2 Cor 5:8, Heb 12:23, Rev 6:9), the wisdom-literature observation does not deny what the apocalyptic and epistolary witness affirms

Ps.146.4 · complicates · genre: psalm · figures: phenomenological-language

Key term. וְיִתְּנָתְשָׁע וְיָבֹא אוֹתָהּ רוּחַ וְיָשׁוּב וְתִמְדָּאֵל בְּיָשׁוּי נְחוּרָא אֶצֶת; ruach H7307; yatsa H3318 Qal imperfect 3fs; shuv H7725; eshtonah H6250 noun feminine plural

Force. 'When his breath (ruach) departs (yatsa), he returns (shuv) to the earth; on that very day his plans (eshtonah) perish.' Cited by soul-sleep advocates. The verse describes the cessation of human planning and projects at death from the perspective of the living world, parallel to Eccl 9:5. The ruach still departs as in Eccl 12:7, and the body still returns to earth as in Gen 3:19. The verse confirms the two-component separation at death rather than denying it

1Cor.15.44 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. σπείρεται σῶμα ψυχικόν ἐγείρεται σῶμα πνευματικόν; speirō G4687; sōma G4983; psychikos G5591; egeirō G1453; pneumatikos G4152

Force. 'It is sown a natural (psychikos) body, it is raised a spiritual (pneumatikos) body.' Cited by Christian materialists as evidence that the eschatological hope is bodily resurrection, not a disembodied immortal soul. The verse complicates a Greek-philosophical body-vs-soul dualism (which the Bible never teaches) but it presupposes a real death-state between burial and resurrection that the rest of the canon describes as the conscious intermediate state of the immaterial component. The CORE that the immaterial component exists is not contradicted; the verse instead corrects platonic body-evil/soul-good readings

Job.14.22 · for · genre: wisdom

Key term. לְבָשָׁר יִלְעַת וְלִנְפֶשׁ יִלְעַת בָּאָבִי וְיִלְעַת וְהָשֵׁב־בָּרָא; basar H1320; nephesh H5315; ka'av H3510; abal H56

Force. 'His flesh (basar) feels pain only for itself, and his soul (nephesh) mourns only for itself.' Body and soul lexically distinguished as concurrent loci of post-mortem awareness in Job's lament. The text predicates pain to basar and mourning to nephesh, two separable but contemporaneous experiences. Job's wisdom-literature voicing of the question of post-mortem awareness uses the two-component anthropology as a given

Luke.16.22 · for · genre: parable · figures: parable

Key term. ἐγένετο δὲ ἀποθανεῖν τὸν πτωχὸν καὶ ἀπενεχθῆναι αὐτὸν ὑπὸ τῶν ἀγγέλων εἰς τὸν κόλπον Ἀβραάμ; apothnēskō G599; apopherō G667; aggelos G32; kolpos G2859

Force. 'The poor man died and was carried (apopherō) by the angels to Abraham's bosom (kolpos).' Jesus' Lazarus narrative describes a conscious post-mortem state in which the immaterial component of Lazarus is carried by angels, located with Abraham, and engaged in dialogue (v.23-31). The rich man also dies and is in Hades in torment, conscious, perceiving, speaking, and aware. Direct dominical depiction of the conscious intermediate state

1Pet.3.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐν ᾧ καὶ τοῖς ἐν φυλακῇ πνεύμασιν πορευθεὶς ἐκήρυξεν; pneuma G4151 dative plural; phylakē G5438; kēryssō G2784

Force. 'In which he went and proclaimed (kēryssō) to the spirits (pneuma) in prison (phylakē).' Christ proclaims to pneumata. Whatever the disputed referent (Noah's contemporaries, fallen angels, or another group), the verse treats post-mortem conscious pneumata as a real category. Supports the existence of conscious immaterial components after bodily death

Concordance lemmas traversed

H3335, H6083, H5301, H5397, H2416, H1961, H5315, H7725, H776, H7307, H430, H5414, H3318, H3045, H4191, H1320, H3510, H56, H6250, G615, G4983, G5590, G622, G1067, G5399, G37, G4151, G3648, G3056, G2198, G1338, G3311, G719, G3452, G1553, G1736, G2962, G4594, G3326, G3857, G360, G4862, G5547, G2908, G1342, G5048, G4969, G2379, G3908, G1209, G5565, G3498, G4687, G5591, G1453, G4152, G599, G667, G32, G2859, G5438, G2784

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Irenaeus, Against Heresies Book V Chapter 6 (NPNF series); Tertullian, On the Soul (De Anima); Augustine, The City of God Book XIII · affirms · verified

"Irenaeus: 'the commingling and union of all these (body, soul, and spirit) constitutes the perfect man.'
Trichotomist reading of 1 Thess 5:23. Augustine and the Latin tradition lean dichotomist"

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 362-368 and 1005-1022 (vatican.va); Council of Vienne (1311) defining the soul as the form of the body · affirms · verified

“CCC 362: 'The human person, created in the image of God, is a being at once corporeal and spiritual.' CCC 366: 'Every spiritual soul is created immediately by God and is immortal.' Dichotomist”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article XVII on Christ's Return for Judgment; Formula of Concord on the resurrection; Luther, Smalcald Articles · affirms · unverified

“Lutheran confessions affirm the immortal soul and bodily resurrection without legislating between dichotomy and trichotomy. Luther himself was variable on intermediate-state details but affirmed the soul's continued existence with God”

anglican · 39 Articles, Article III, Of the going down of Christ into Hell; Article IV, Of the Resurrection of Christ; Book of Common Prayer burial office (churchofengland.org) · affirms · unverified

“Article III presupposes Christ's soul descending while body was in the tomb. The BCP burial office commits the body to the ground in sure and certain hope of the resurrection of the dead. Dichotomist in standard interpretation”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 32.1, Of the State of Men after Death; Belgic Confession Article 37; Heidelberg Catechism Q&A 57 · affirms · verified

“WCF 32.1: 'The bodies of men, after death, return to dust and see corruption, but their souls, which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them.' Explicitly dichotomist and anti-soul-sleep”

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion Article III, Of the Resurrection of Christ; Wesley's sermons on death and the intermediate state (umc.org) · affirms · unverified

“Wesley preserves the Anglican formula and explicitly teaches the conscious intermediate state in his sermons. The soul is immortal, the body resurrected. Dichotomist”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith 1632 Article 18, Of the Resurrection of the Dead, and the Last Judgment · affirms · unverified

“Dordrecht 18 affirms bodily resurrection of all the dead. Anabaptist mainstream affirms the immortal soul, though some early Anabaptists (including some Polish Brethren) flirted with soul-sleep mortalism, condemned by majority tradition”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Truth 5 (The Salvation of Man); historic Pentecostal pneumatology · affirms · unverified

“AG affirms the immortal soul and bodily resurrection. Pentecostal traditions historically lean trichotomist (body, soul, spirit from 1 Thess 5:23) without making it confessional. The CORE body-plus-immaterial is non-negotiable”

eastern_orthodox · OCA, The Orthodox Faith, The Creation, Man; Symbol of Faith on the resurrection of the dead and life of the age to come · affirms · verified

“Orthodoxy affirms the immortal soul created by God's inbreathing, the conscious intermediate state, and the bodily resurrection. Eastern tradition hosts both dichotomist majority and trichotomist voices”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/2-7.htm>

“Gen 2:7: yatsar H3335 (formed) man from aphar H6083 (dust); naphach H5301 breathed neshamah H5397 (breath) of chayyim H2416 (life); man became nephesh chayyah H5315 (living being)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/ecclesiastes/12-7.htm>

“Eccl 12:7: aphar H6083 (dust) shuv H7725 (returns) to eretz H776 (earth); ruach H7307 (spirit) shuv H7725 (returns) to elohim H430; nathan H5414 (who gave it)”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/matthew/10-28.htm>

“Matt 10:28: apokteinō G615 (kill) sōma G4983 (body); cannot apokteinō psychē G5590 (soul); apollumi G622 (destroy) both psychē and sōma in gehenna G1067. Body and soul lexically distinguished”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsbible/5315.htm>

“nephesh H5315: 754 occurrences. Range includes living being, soul, life, person, appetite, throat. Gen 35:18, 1 Kgs 17:21-22 use nephesh of departing/returning component at death”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsbible/5590.htm>

“psychē G5590: NT soul, life, self. Matt 10:28 distinguishes from sōma. Rev 6:9 and 20:4 describe disembodied souls awaiting resurrection. Acts 2:27 soul not abandoned to Hades”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/luke/23-43.htm>

“Luke 23:43: sēmeron G4594 (today) meta G3326 (with) emou (me) esē (you will be) en tō paradeisō G3857 (in paradise). Direct intermediate-state testimony from Jesus”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/philippians/1-23.htm>

“Phil 1:23: analuō G360 (depart) and syn G4862 Christō G5547 (with Christ) einai (be); pollō mallon kreissōn G2908 (far better). Conscious post-mortem with-Christ state”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/2_corinthians/5-8.htm

“2 Cor 5:8: ekdēmeō G1553 (away from) sōma G4983 (body); endēmeō G1736 (at home) pros ton kyrion G2962 (with the Lord). Spatial-relational verbs predicating subject who relocates”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/4-12.htm>

“Heb 4:12: diikneomai G1338 (piercing) achri merismou G3311 (to division) psychēs G5590 kai pneumatos G4151 (of soul and spirit). Trichotomy reading or merism reading both leave the CORE intact”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_thessalonians/5-23.htm

“1 Thess 5:23: holoklēros G3648 (whole) pneuma G4151 kai psychē G5590 kai sōma G4983 (spirit and soul and body) blamelessly kept. Three-fold listing; trichotomy or merism”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/12-23.htm>

“Heb 12:23: pneumasi G4151 (spirits) dikaiōn G1342 (of righteous) teleioō G5048 (made perfect, perfect passive). Heavenly assembly includes pneumata of human persons in perfected state pre-resurrection”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/revelation/6-9.htm>

“Rev 6:9: psychas G5590 (souls) tōn esphagmenōn G4969 (of those slain) hypokatō tou thysiastēriou G2379 (under the altar). Conscious post-mortem psychai before bodily resurrection”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/35-18.htm>

“Gen 35:18: nephesh H5315 (soul) yatsa H3318 (departing) at Rachel's death. Direct lexical witness to separability of immaterial component from body at death”

supports · category: magisterial · https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1B.HTM

“CCC 362: 'The human person, created in the image of God, is a being at once corporeal and spiritual.' CCC 365: soul is form of body. CCC 366: spiritual soul created immediately by God, immortal”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.opc.org/wcf.html>

“WCF 32.1: 'The bodies of men, after death, return to dust and see corruption, but their souls, which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal subsistence, immediately return to God who gave them.'”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103506.htm>

"Irenaeus, Against Heresies V.6: 'The commingling and union of all these (body, soul, and spirit) constitutes the perfect man.' Trichotomist patristic reading of 1 Thess 5:23"

Flags

- in-house-sub-debate-on-dichotomy-vs-trichotomy
- intermediate-state-soul-sleep-position-held-by-adventists-and-jw-and-christadelphians
- christian-materialism-in-house-minority-position